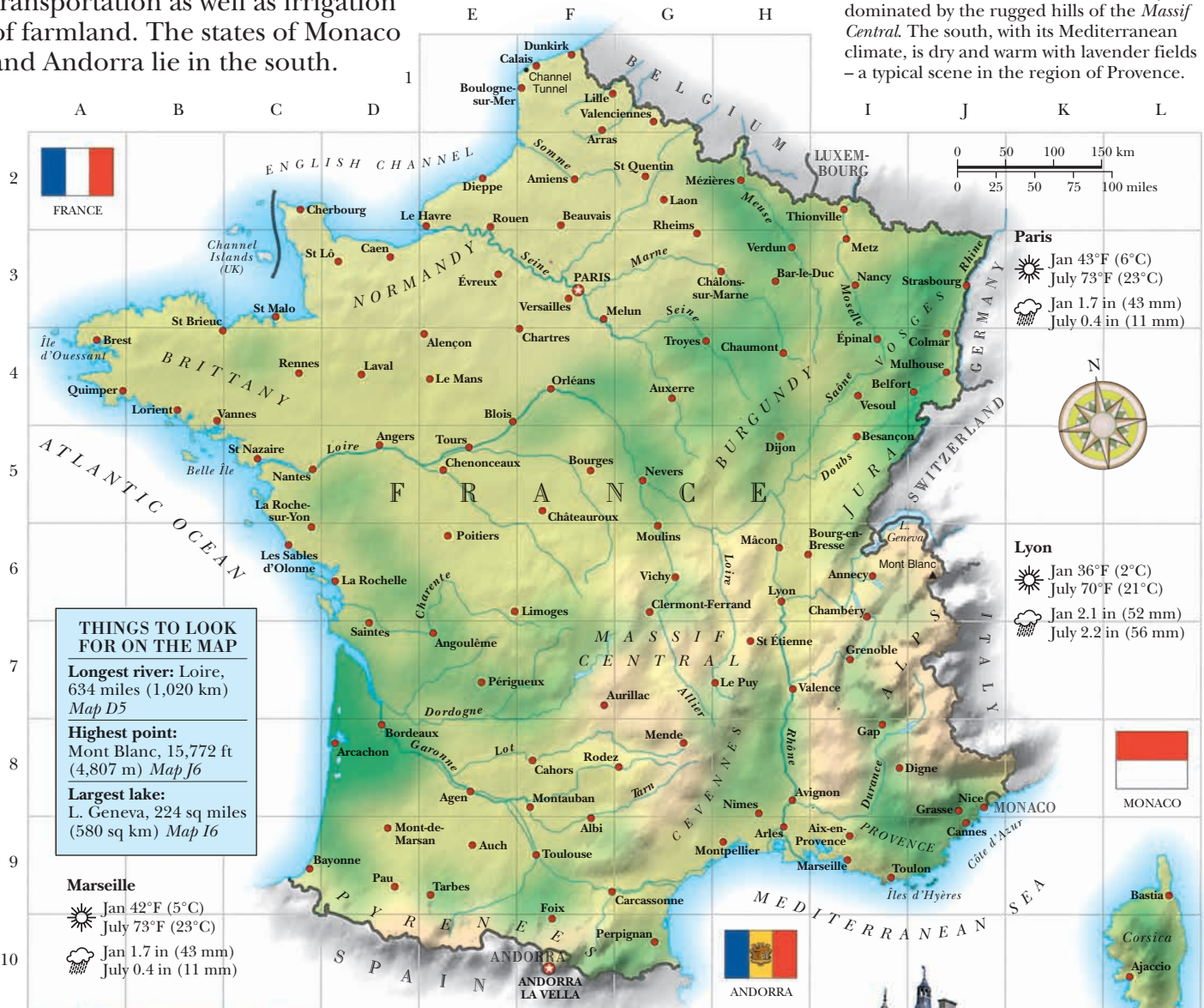


FRANCE

THE LARGEST COUNTRY IN western Europe, France includes the island of Corsica in the Mediterranean Sea. Two major mountain chains, the Pyrenees to the south and the Alps to the east, provide dramatic natural borders with neighboring countries. Several rivers, including the Loire, the Rhône, and the Seine, are important for transportation as well as irrigation of farmland. The states of Monaco and Andorra lie in the south.



LANDSCAPE
The landscape and climate of France varies from north to south. Northern France has gently rolling farmland with cool, wet weather, while the middle of the country is dominated by the rugged hills of the *Massif Central*. The south, with its Mediterranean climate, is dry and warm with lavender fields – a typical scene in the region of Provence.



FRENCH HISTORY

For hundreds of years, France was ruled by kings and queens. They built magnificent palaces and castles, such as Chenonceau, along the Loire River. All this was swept away in the revolution of 1789. The monarchy was overthrown and King Louis XVI and his queen, Marie Antoinette, were publicly beheaded. In 1792, France became a republic. Despite some efforts to restore the monarchy, France remains a republic.

